



CREATIVES AND PUBLIC DEMONSTRATIONS: PARTICIPATION, RISKS, AND IMPACT

A survey report based on the context of the
events of June 2024 and June 2025



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At the intersection of creativity and critical inquiry

Utetezi is a cultural insight and creative analytics organisation that works at the intersection of creativity and critical inquiry. We bridge artistic expression with data-driven analysis to strengthen decision-making, innovation, and sustainability across the Cultural and Creative Industries (CCIs).



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Abbreviations, Acronyms, Glossary and Key Terms

1. Acronyms & Abbreviations

Term	Definition/Usage in this Report	Cross-references
CCIs	Cultural and Creative Industries. In this report, CCIs refer to the wider ecosystem of artistic, cultural, creative, media, and related professional practices in which respondents operate.	Creative Sector; Creative Ecosystem
NGOs	Non-Governmental Organisations. Used to refer to civil society, advocacy, development, or support organisations operating outside government structures.	Civil Society; Stakeholders

2. Research & Survey Terms

Term	Definition/Usage in this Report	Cross-references
Respondent	A person who completed the survey. The term should be used when referring to survey data.	Survey Participant; Sample
Survey Participant	A person who contributed data to the survey. This term may be used interchangeably with respondent.	Respondent

Sample	The group of creatives whose survey responses form the basis of the report. It should not be read as representing every creative in Kenya.	Respondent; Demographic Profile
Demographic Profile	The descriptive breakdown of respondents by factors such as age, location, and creative category. In this report, it helps contextualise participation patterns.	Age Group; County Distribution
Age Group	A survey category used to compare respondents by age ranges. It supports discussion of Gen Z, young millennials, and generational participation patterns.	Gen Z; Millennials
County Distribution	The geographic spread of respondents by county. In this report, it shows where Demographic survey respondents were based, not the full geographic spread of protests or creative activism in Kenya.	Sample
Quantitative Data	Numerical survey evidence such as counts, percentages, and category distributions. Quantitative data is used to show participation levels, risks, and sector patterns.	Count; Percentage
Qualitative Data	Written or open-ended responses used to interpret motivations, barriers, risks, and aspirations. It adds context to the numerical findings.	Open-ended Responses; Thematic Analysis

Open-ended Responses	Survey answers where respondents expressed themselves in their own words rather than selecting options.	Qualitative Data
Inductive Thematic Analysis	A qualitative analysis approach where themes are developed from respondent language and patterns in the data. It is used to analyse open-ended responses.	Coding Framework; Theme
Familiarisation	The first stage of qualitative analysis, involving repeated reading of responses to understand meaning and sentiment.	Inductive Thematic Analysis
Open Coding	The process of assigning initial labels to meaningful segments of respondent text. It supports the identification of recurring patterns.	Code; Coding Framework
Code	A short analytical label assigned to a recurring idea in qualitative responses. Codes are grouped into broader themes.	Theme; Sub-theme
Theme	A broader pattern or area of meaning developed from related codes. Themes are used to summarise patterns across respondents.	Code; Sub-theme
Sub-theme	A more specific pattern within a larger theme. It helps organise related but distinct ideas in the report's qualitative analysis.	Theme; Coding Framework

Coding Framework	The structured table of themes, sub-themes, codes, definitions, and illustrative examples used to organise qualitative findings.	Inductive Thematic Analysis
Theme Validation	The process of checking whether themes are coherent, clearly bounded, and supported by respondent data.	Inductive Thematic Analysis
Count	The number of respondents or selections associated with a category. Counts are often paired with percentages.	Percentage; Total
Percentage	The proportion of respondents or selections represented by a finding. Percentages should be read in relation to the relevant question and sample size.	Count
Multiple Selection	A survey format allowing respondents to choose more than one option. In such questions, total selections may exceed the number of respondents.	Total Selections
Total Selections	The total number of selected options in a multiple-selection question. This may be higher than the number of respondents.	Multiple Selection
Unspecified	Used where a respondent did not provide sufficient information for classification, or where the data could not be assigned to a clear category.	Sample; Category Distribution

Category-specific Engagement	Analysis comparing participation patterns across different creative disciplines. In this report, it shows how creative form influences the mode, intensity, and visibility of civic engagement.	Creative Category; Participation
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Creative Category Distribution	The breakdown of respondents by creative discipline. It should be interpreted as the composition of the survey sample, not as a ranking of activism across the entire sector.	Creative Category; Multidisciplinary
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3. Civic and Social Action Terms

Term	Definition/Usage in this Report	Cross-references
Maandamano	A Swahili term commonly used in Kenya to refer to public demonstrations or protests. In this report, it refers specifically to civic mobilisation around the June 2024 protests and related June 2025 memorial actions.	Public Demonstrations; Protest Participation
Public Demonstrations	The formal English term used alongside maandamano. In this report, it includes physical protest activity as well as associated public civic actions.	Maandamano

June 2024 Protests	The protest cycle that forms the primary civic context for the report. The term is used descriptively to refer to the period of youth-led public mobilisation in Kenya.	Maandamano; Youth-led Protests
June 2025 Memorial Resurgence	The commemorative or memorial civic activity connected to the June 2024 protest cycle.	Memorialisation; Commemoration
Memorialisation	The act of remembering, marking, or publicly reflecting on past civic events, losses, or struggles.	June 2025 Memorial Resurgence;
Commemoration	Public or collective remembrance of a significant event.	Memorialisation
Youth-led Protests	Protest actions strongly associated with younger participants and digital mobilisation. The term should not imply that all young people participated or held identical views.	Gen Z; Millennials
Gen Z	A generational category used to discuss younger respondents and the wider perception of youth-led activism. The term should not be used to imply uniform political attitudes among all young people.	Youth-led Protests; Digital Engagement
Millennials	A generational category used to distinguish older young adults from Gen Z respondents.	Gen Z; Age Group

Civic Expression	Public expression of social or political concern through speech, art, media, performance, or other forms of communication. In this report, civic expression links creative work to public issues.	Creative Activism; Artistic Expression
Civic Participation	Broad involvement in public issues or civic life. In this report, it includes protest attendance, online engagement, artistic expression, and supportive actions.	Participation; Protest Participation
Activism	Purposeful action intended to influence social, political, or systemic change. Activism includes but is not limited to physical protest.	Creative Activism; Advocacy
Creative Activism	The use of creative practice, artistic expression, cultural production, or media work to support civic engagement, critique power, raise awareness, or mobilise public imagination.	Activism; Civic Expression
Advocacy	Efforts to promote, defend, or advance a cause, right, policy, or public interest.	Activism; Policy Protections
Political Engagement	Engagement with governance, rights, public policy, or political processes. The term does not necessarily refer to party politics.	Governance Issues; Civic Participation

Civic Duty	A sense of responsibility to contribute to public life, speak out, document events, or influence society.	Creative Responsibility
Governance Issues	Public concerns relating to leadership, accountability, corruption, public institutions, rights, and state response. The term is used descriptively and neutrally.	Political Engagement; Systemic Change
Public Discourse	The wider public conversation around social and political issues. In this report, creatives are treated as contributors to public discourse through their work and platforms.	Civic Expression
Collective Action	Coordinated or shared action by individuals or groups around a common public concern. It includes both physical mobilisation and networked support.	Solidarity; Mobilisation
Mobilisation	The process of encouraging, organising, or enabling people to act around a public issue. Mobilisation can occur physically, digitally, or through creative work.	Collective Action; Digital Engagement
Decentralised Organisation	A form of organisation without a single clear centre, leader, or formal structure.	Youth-led Protests; Online Activism
Participation	Involvement in the civic or protest-related actions examined in the report. It includes both physical and non-physical forms of engagement.	Direct Participation; Indirect Participation

Protest Participation	Involvement in demonstrations or protest-related civic actions. In this report, it includes physical presence, artistic/online expression, and other forms of contribution.	Participation; Physical Participation
Non-participation	Not taking part in the civic actions being measured. In this report, non-participation does not automatically mean indifference; it may include support, neutrality, fear, or other constraints.	Protest Support; Neutrality
Direct Participation	Active and visible involvement in civic action, such as attending demonstrations, publicly creating protest-related work, documenting events, or contributing directly to mobilisation.	Physical Participation
Indirect Participation	Supportive or related civic engagement without direct participation in demonstrations or public protest activity. This may include amplification, solidarity, resource support, or indirect creative contribution.	Supportive Actions
Physical Participation	Participation involving physical presence at demonstrations, public gatherings, performances, or related civic actions.	Protest Participation
Non-physical Participation	Participation that does not require physical presence, including online activism, artistic expression, documentation, sharing information, or remote support.	Online Activism; Artistic/Online Expression

Artistic/Online Expression	A survey participation category referring to civic engagement through creative work or online platforms. It captures respondents who may not have been physically present but still participated through expression.	Non-physical Participation
Online Activism	Civic engagement conducted through digital platforms, including social media, digital storytelling, content sharing, online campaigns, and rapid-response communication.	Digital Engagement
Digital Engagement	The use of digital tools and platforms for civic communication, mobilisation, documentation, and public visibility.	Online Activism; Digital Platforms
Digital Platforms	Online spaces used to publish, circulate, or amplify civic messages.	Online Activism
Supportive Actions	Actions that show support for a cause without necessarily involving protest attendance. These may include sharing information, amplifying messages, offering resources, creating supportive content, or expressing solidarity.	Indirect Participation; Protest Support
Protest Support	Agreement with or support for the cause of demonstrations without necessarily participating directly.	Non-participation; Supportive Actions
Neutrality	A reported position where a respondent chose not to participate or openly align with the cause. It should be treated as a specific response category, not assumed as silence.	Non-participation

Fear of Violence	A stated deterrent to participation, including fear of physical harm, online attacks, or other forms of violence.	Risk; Non-participation
Risk	Potential harm associated with civic expression or demonstration participation. In this report, risk includes personal safety, legal consequences, emotional strain, and professional effects.	Reported Risks; State Surveillance
Reported Risks	Risks identified by respondents in relation to activism or demonstrations.	Risk
State Surveillance	The fear or perception that protest activity or civic expression may be monitored by state actors.	Risk; Civic Space
Arrest	A detainment risk that appears as part of the risk environment surrounding demonstrations.	Risk
Professional Blacklisting	The fear that civic expression or protest involvement could reduce or hinder access to work, opportunities, networks, or institutional support.	Professional Risk
Censorship	The restriction, silencing, or suppression of artistic or civic expression.	Free Expression; Suppression
Suppression	Structural, institutional, or social pressure that limits expression, participation, or dissent.	Censorship; Structural Barriers

Free Expression	The Constitutional ability to speak, create, perform, publish, or participate without intimidation or punishment.	Rights; Civic Space
Constitutional Rights	Rights-based protections invoked in relation to expression, safety, assembly, and participation. The term should be used descriptively, not as legal advice.	Free Expression
Civic Space	The social, legal, and institutional environment that enables people and organisations to express themselves, organise, and participate safely.	Free Expression; Civil Society
Civic Education	Knowledge-building around rights, governance, public responsibility, and meaningful participation. In this report, civic education is linked to purposeful and informed activism.	Strategic Activism
Strategic Activism	Activism that is informed, purposeful, and directed toward clear objectives. In this report, it is contrasted with performative or poorly structured action.	Civic Education; Activism
Systemic Change	Broad structural reform in governance, institutions, policy, rights protection, or sector support.	Governance Issues; Advocacy
Structural Barriers	Conditions that limit creative or civic participation, such as suppression, lack of protection, limited support, insecurity, or economic constraints.	Systemic Change; Censorship

Solidarity	Mutual support, unity, or collective alignment among creatives and civic actors.	Collective Action
Social Cohesion	The strengthening of social connection, mutual understanding, and shared belonging.	Collective Action
Emotional Weight	The psychological and emotional burden associated with creating or speaking out during politically charged moments.	Resilience; Burnout
Resilience	The capacity to continue creating, speaking, or supporting civic causes despite risk, fatigue, or discouragement.	Emotional Weight
Burnout	Emotional or creative fatigue linked to sustained activism, public pressure, or repeated exposure to political stress.	Emotional Weight; Risk
Cancel Culture	Social or online backlash that may pressure creatives to apologise, withdraw, or self-censor.	Online Activism; Risk
Policy Protections	Institutional or legal safeguards that protect creatives' rights, safety, work, and freedom of expression.	Advocacy; Free Expression
Fair Pay	Adequate compensation for creative labour.	Professional & Economic Considerations
Professional & Economic Considerations	Practical concerns affecting creatives' ability to sustain their work, including jobs, pay, opportunity, recognition, and sector development.	Fair Pay; Creative Sector

4. Creative Sector Terms

Term	Definition/Usage in this Report	Cross-references
Creatives	A collective term for people engaged in artistic, cultural, media, design, literary, performance, or creative-sector work. It includes more than artists alone and may include practitioners, producers, educators, managers, and media workers.	Creative Sector; CCI
Creative Sector	The broad field of creative, cultural, artistic, media, design, performance, literary, and related professional activity.	CCI ; Creative Ecosystem
Creative Ecosystem	The network of creatives, organisations, audiences, institutions, funders, platforms, and support systems that shape creative work.	Creative Sector
Creative Practice	The process, discipline, or method through which a creative develops and produces work. It is broader than activism and may or may not involve civic themes.	Artistic Expression
Artistic Expression	The use of artistic forms to communicate ideas, emotions, stories, or critique. In this report, artistic expression becomes civic when it engages social or political issues.	Creative Expression; Civic Expression
Creative Expression	A broader term covering artistic, design, media, literary, performance, digital, and cultural forms of expression. It includes but is not limited to formal art-making.	Artistic Expression

Cultural Production	The making and circulation of cultural or creative outputs, including performances, films, writing, visual work, media, and community-based creative forms.	Creative Practice
Multidisciplinary	Describes creative work or identity that spans more than one discipline. In this report, the term is important because many respondents' civic expression cannot be reduced to a single creative category.	Creative Category Distribution
Medium	The creative form or tool through which expression occurs, such as performance, video, writing, design, music, or digital content.	Dissemination Pathways
Workflow	The production process and timeline behind a creative practice.	Real-time Response
Dissemination Pathways	The channels through which creative work reaches audiences, such as social media, live performance, publication, community networks, or broadcast media.	Digital Platforms; Public Discourse
Real-time Response	The ability to create, document, or circulate work quickly during fast-moving civic moments.	Digital Engagement
Audiovisual Storytelling	Storytelling through sound and moving images, including film, video, animation, and related formats.	Film, Video & Animation

Public Performance	Live presentation or performance in public or community-facing spaces.	Performance & Live Arts
Multi-modal Expression	The use of multiple artistic or media forms to communicate civic messages. In this report, it includes combinations of video, music, poetry, fashion, visuals, performance, and digital tools.	Creative Activism
Aesthetic Protest	The use of style, imagery, design, fashion, humour, performance, or artistic form as a mode of protest or critique.	Multi-modal Expression
Creative Responsibility	The belief that creatives have a role in documenting, interpreting, challenging, or reflecting society.	Civic Duty
Performance & Live Arts	A creative category covering live and embodied practices such as theatre, music, dance, spoken word, performance, and related forms.	Public Performance
Film, Video & Animation	A creative category covering moving-image practices, including film, video production, animation, editing, and related audiovisual forms.	Audiovisual Storytelling
Digital Content & Advertising	A creative category covering digital media production, online content, branding, advertising, campaign communication, and platform-based creative work.	Online Activism; Digital Platforms

Writing & Literature	A creative category covering written and literary practices, including poetry, fiction, essays, scripts, publishing, and other written expression.	Artistic Expression
Visual & Design Arts	A creative category covering visual art, illustration, graphic design, photography, painting, layout design, and related visual communication practices.	Aesthetic Protest
Creative Business & Management	A creative category covering the organisational, entrepreneurial, administrative, production, marketing, and management functions that support creative work.	Creative Ecosystem
Journalism & Media	A creative and communication category covering reporting, media production, documentation, storytelling, and public information practices.	Public Discourse
Education & Capacity Building	A category covering teaching, mentorship, training, knowledge-sharing, skills development, and learning support within creative or civic contexts.	Civic Education
Cultural Heritage & Indigenous Knowledge	A combined creative category covering cultural preservation, traditional knowledge, heritage practices, community memory, and indigenous knowledge systems.	Cultural Heritage; Indigenous Knowledge

Cultural Heritage	Cultural practices, memory, traditions, artefacts, and forms of expression inherited or transmitted across communities.	Cultural Heritage & Indigenous Knowledge
Indigenous Knowledge	Community-rooted knowledge systems, practices, and ways of understanding that are locally held and transmitted.	Cultural Heritage & Indigenous Knowledge
Crafts & Material Arts	A creative category covering handmade, tactile, object-based, and material practices such as craft, textile work, handmade design, and related forms.	Medium; Workflow
Interactive & Emerging Media	A creative category covering technology-enabled, interactive, immersive, experimental, or new media practices.	Digital Engagement; Multi-modal Expression

Executive Summary

The report finds that Kenyan creatives are highly engaged in civic life, with 90% of respondents using their creative work to engage political or social issues. Participation in maandamano was substantial but varied: while many were physically present, others contributed through digital expression, documentation, artistic production, amplification, or other supportive actions. The findings show that non-participation should not be read as indifference, as many non-attendees still supported the cause but were constrained by safety, economic, professional, or strategic concerns.

A major generational shift is evident. Younger creatives, particularly Gen Z and young millennials, are using digital platforms, visual storytelling, humour, performance, and public expression to engage civic issues more directly and visibly than previous generations. However, this boldness comes with significant risks, including surveillance, arrest, blacklisting, loss of work, online abuse, burnout, and exposure to violence. The report therefore positions creatives as vital civic actors operating under pressure, and calls for stronger protections, fair pay, funding, safe spaces, collective organising, and policy frameworks that safeguard freedom of expression.

CHAPTER ONE

Introduction

1.1 Contextualising Creatives and Civic Expression

Creatives have long played a central role in Kenya's sociopolitical life, using artistic expression to question power, articulate dissent, and mobilise public imagination. From the cultural nationalism of the independence era, to the coded artistic resistance of the Moi years, to the satirical and multimedia interventions of the early 2000s, artists have consistently been key actors in shaping public discourse and highlighting social and political concerns.

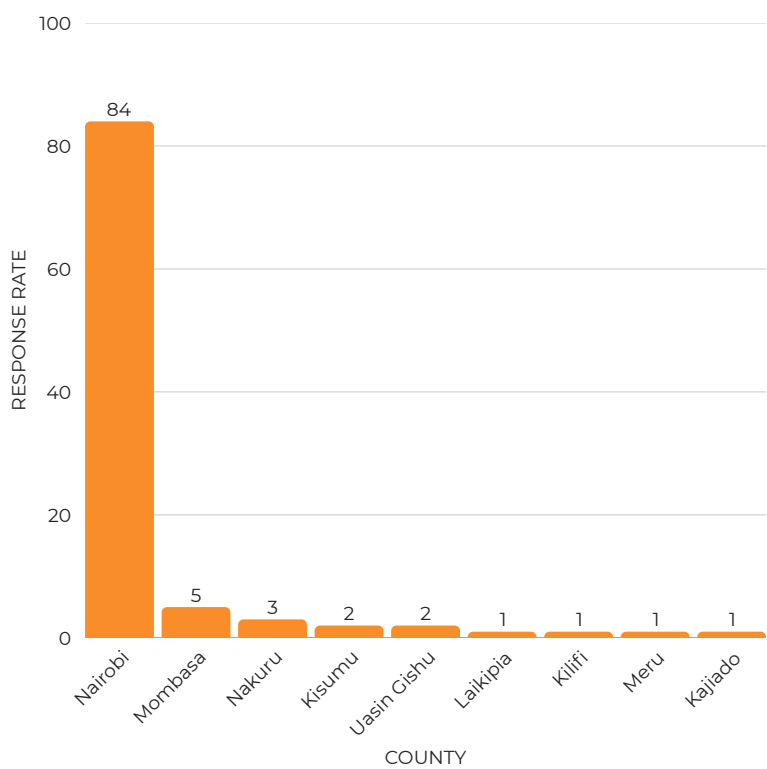
In recent years, particularly during the youth-led protests of June 2024 and their memorialised resurgence in June 2025, the landscape of creative civic expression has entered a new phase. A younger, digitally fluent generation of artists has leveraged social media, audiovisual storytelling, and public performance to document events in real time, amplify public sentiment, and catalyse collective action. This moment is characterised not by the creative activism itself, but by its heightened visibility, accelerated pace, decentralised organisation, and increased personal and professional risks for those involved.

This survey is situated within this contemporary context. It seeks to understand how creatives experienced and articulated their civic engagement during these recent protest cycles. Specifically, it explores their motivations, the challenges they faced, and the aspirations that guide their work at the intersection of artistic practice and sociopolitical expression.

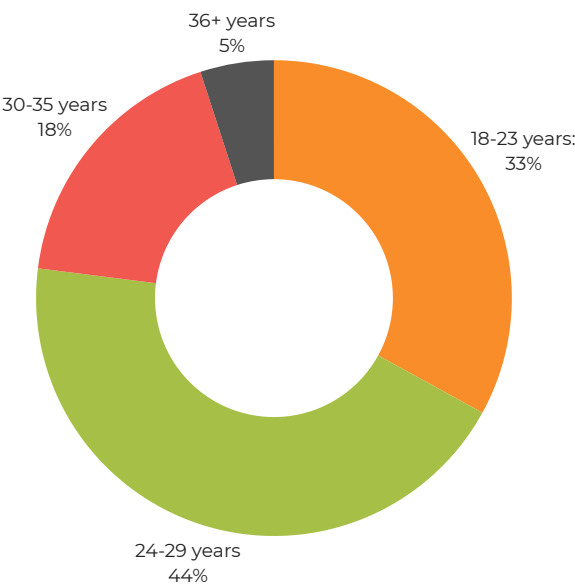
1.2 Demographics: Who Responded?

This demographic profile is based on responses from 102 creatives across Kenya. While the sample is predominantly Nairobi-based (84%), respondents also participated from Mombasa, Nakuru, Kisumu, Uasin Gishu, Laikipia, Kilifi, Meru, and Kajiado.

1.2.1 County Distribution

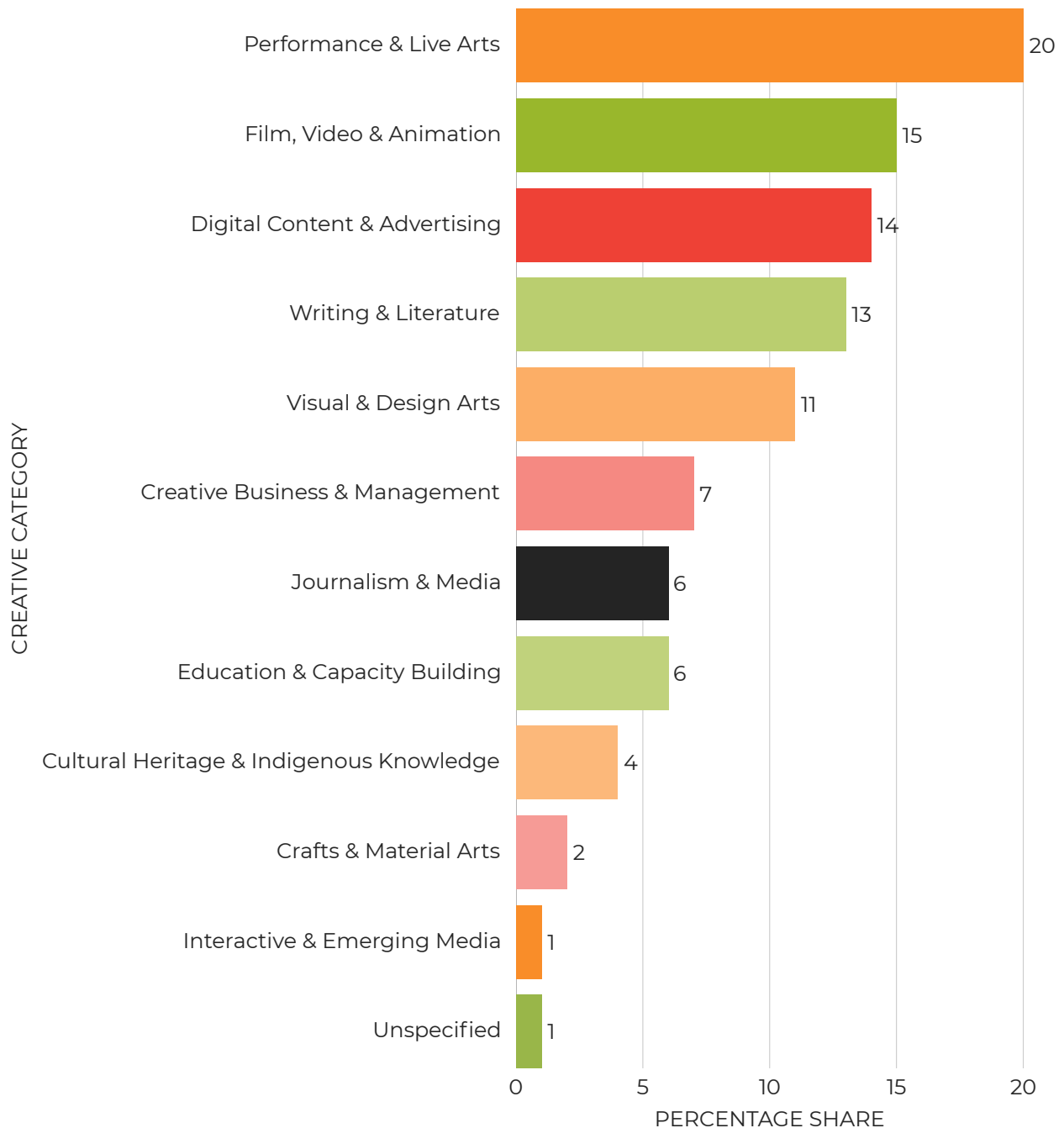


1.2.2 Age Group Distribution



The data reinforces the perception of Gen Z and young millennials as the key drivers of creative activism in Kenya today.

1.2.3 Creative Category Distribution %



The Creative Category distribution shows higher levels of civic engagement among artists in performance and live arts, film, video & animation, digital content & advertising, and writing & literature. While this may appear to reflect greater activism within expressive or narrative-driven fields, the pattern must be interpreted with caution. Many respondents identify as multidisciplinary, meaning their civic expression is shaped by overlapping practices rather than a single artistic category.

Moreover, the visibility and frequency of public engagement are influenced by the nature of creative production and the ease of dissemination. Digital content creators, for example, can rapidly produce and circulate material during fast-moving events, which amplifies their presence within civic spaces. In contrast, creators working in crafts, cultural heritage, or other materially intensive practices face different production timelines, output formats, and distribution channels that inherently limit their ability to respond in real time. These structural differences do not imply lower political consciousness; rather, they highlight that the form of practice influences both the feasibility and mode of participation in civic discourse.

Overall, the findings suggest that the medium, workflow, and dissemination pathways of each creative practice significantly shape how, and how visibly, artists engage during moments of civic mobilisation.

CHAPTER TWO

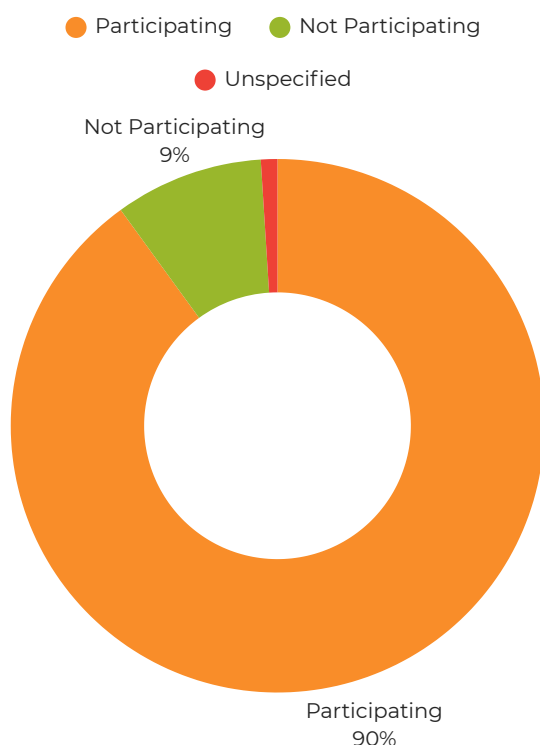
Civic Participation Insights

2.1 How Creatives are Engaging

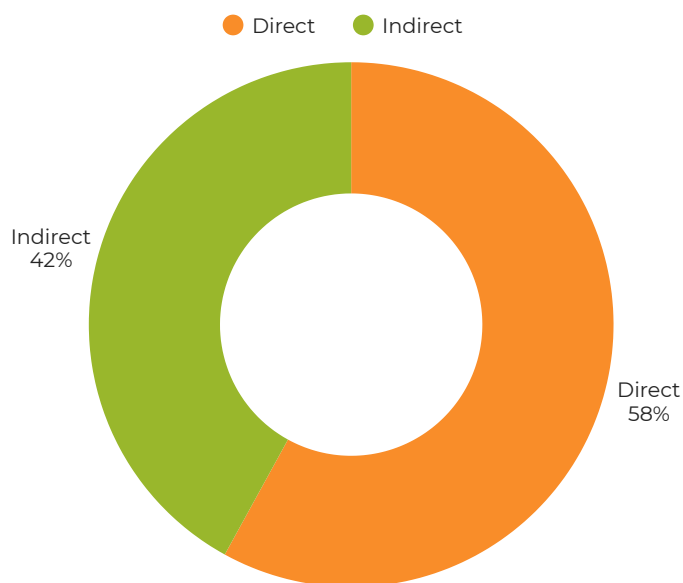
An overwhelming 90% of respondents reported engaging with political or social issues through their creative work, either directly (58%) or indirectly (42%), out of the participating total. Only a small minority did not participate (9%) or did not specify (1%).

2.1.1 Type of Participation

Participation Vs Non-participation



Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation



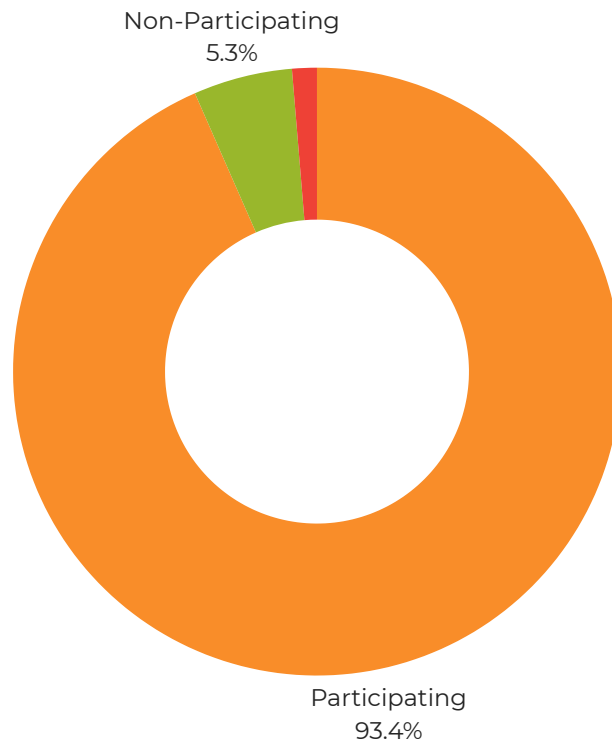
The findings show that civic engagement is broadly embedded within Kenya's creative sector, with most respondents participating in political or social issues through either direct artistic expression or supportive actions that aid visibility and mobilisation. The key insight here is the widespread norm of civic involvement across creative disciplines, while the minimal non-participation indicates that creatives consistently position themselves, whether visibly or indirectly, as contributors to public discourse. This reinforces the sector's role as an influential and civically conscious force in sociopolitical mobilisation.

2.2 Category-specific Engagement

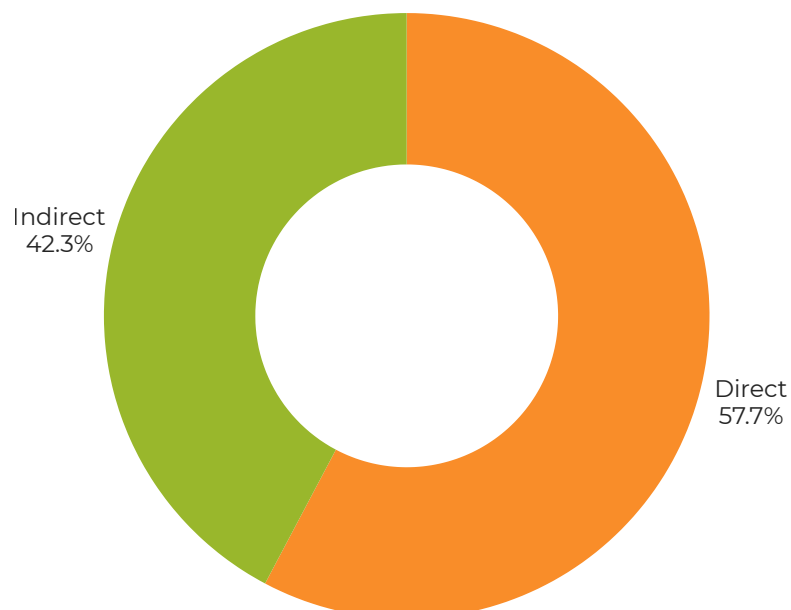
This section examines how civic participation in public demonstrations varies across different creative sectors. While the overall participation rate is high, the intensity and mode of engagement differ by category. Performance and live arts, film, video & animation, and digital content & advertising show the highest levels of direct involvement, reflecting the public-facing and expressive nature of these fields. Other sectors, including writing and literature, visual and design arts, and education, display a mix of direct and indirect engagement, while areas like crafts, cultural heritage, and interactive media tend to engage more indirectly or at lower levels. These patterns suggest that the form and practice of creativity influence both the likelihood and manner of participation in civic actions.

2.2.1 Performance & Live Arts

Participation Vs Non-participation

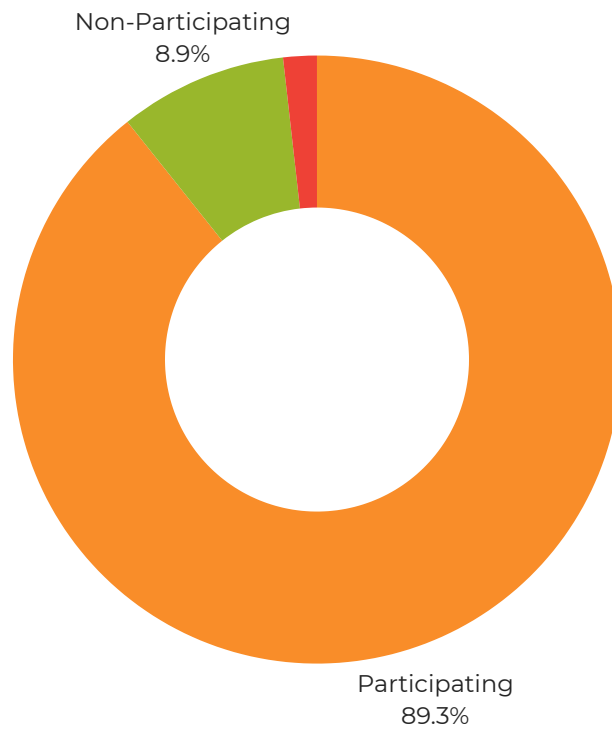


Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation

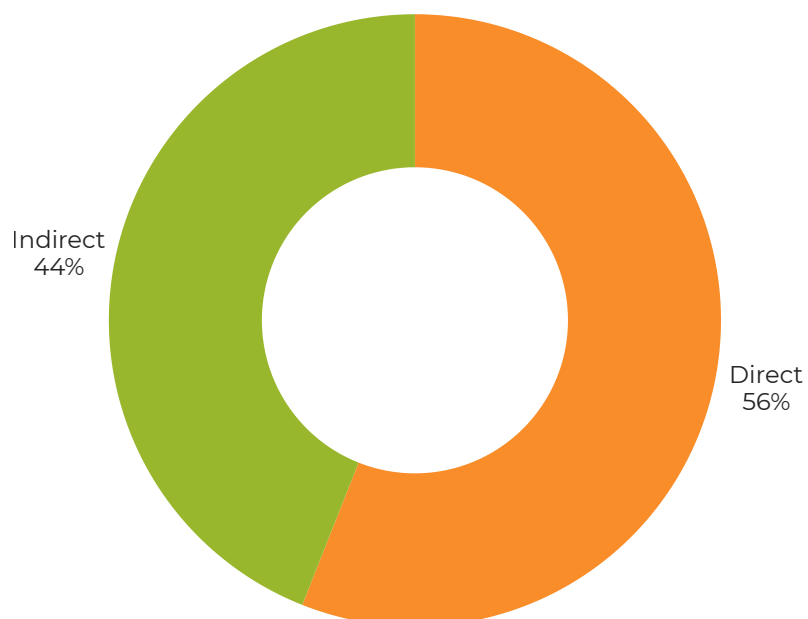


2.2.2 Film, Video & Animation

Participation Vs Non-participation

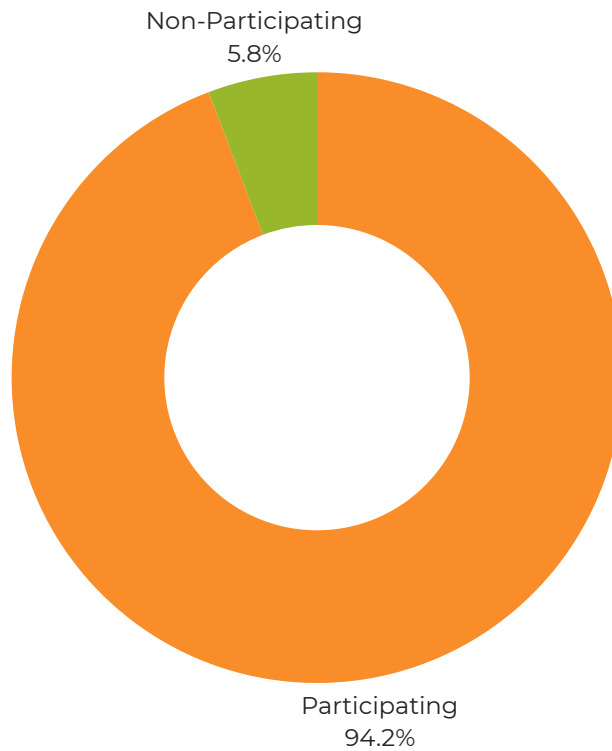


Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation

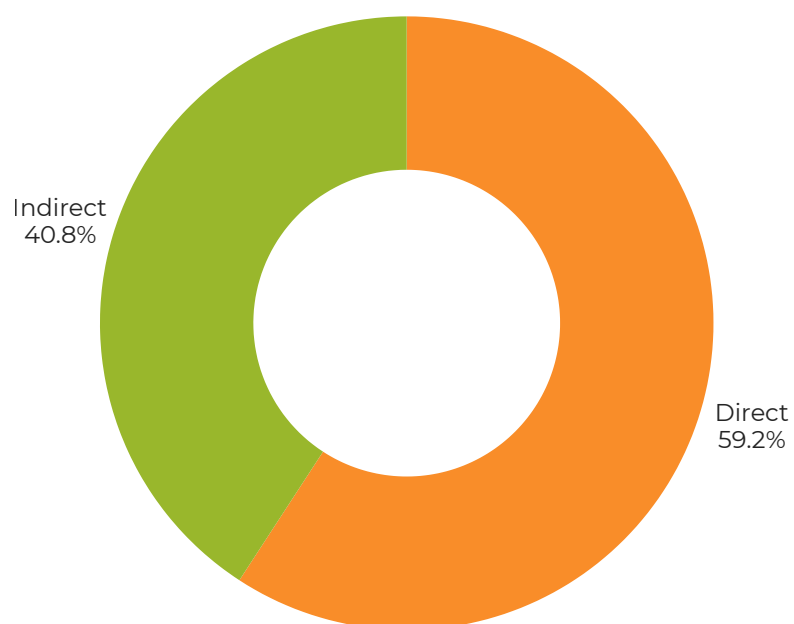


2.2.3 Digital Content & Advertising

Participation Vs Non-participation

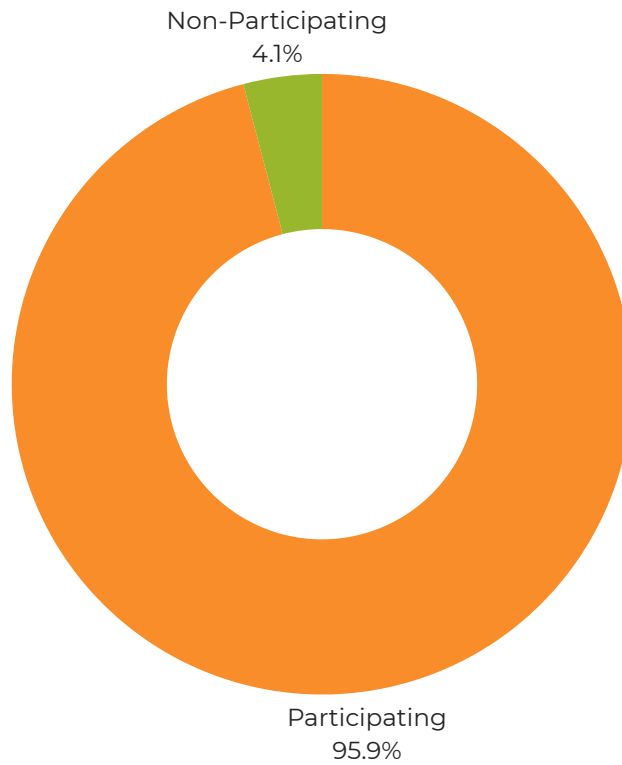


Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation

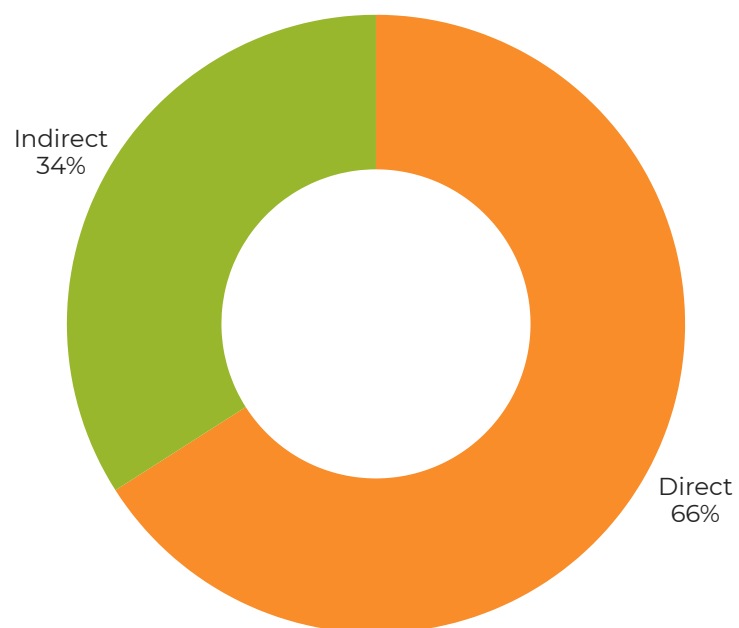


2.2.4 Writing & Literature

Participation Vs Non-participation

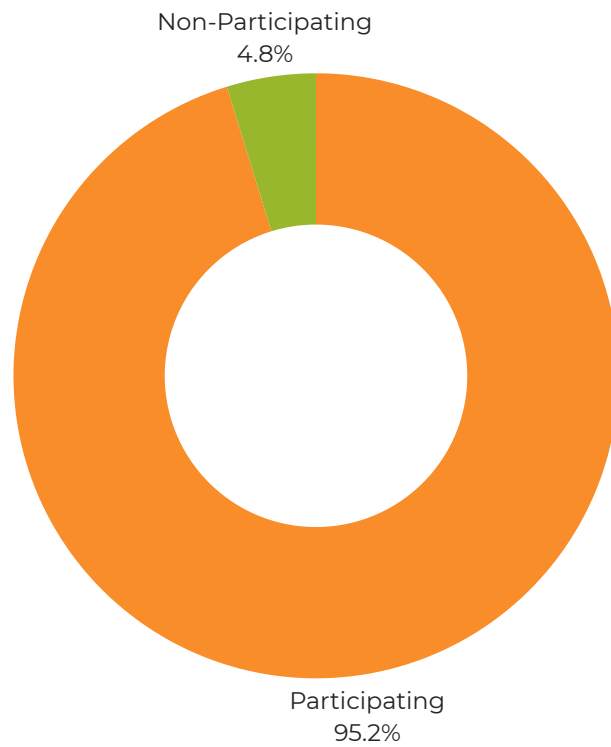


Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation

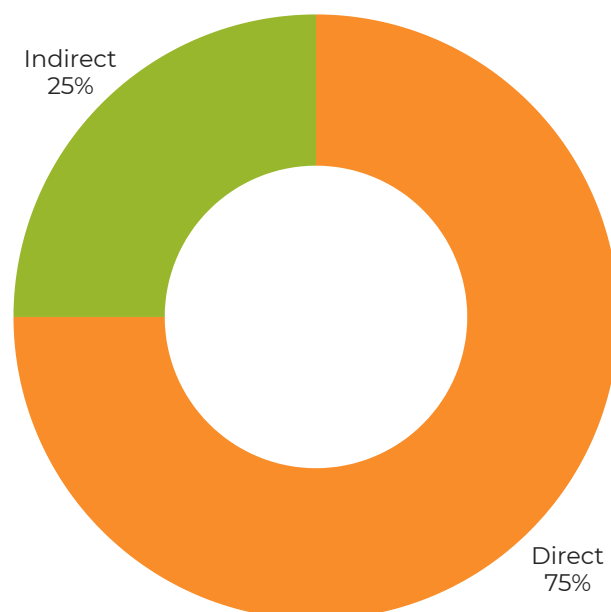


2.2.5 Journalism & Media

Participation Vs Non-participation

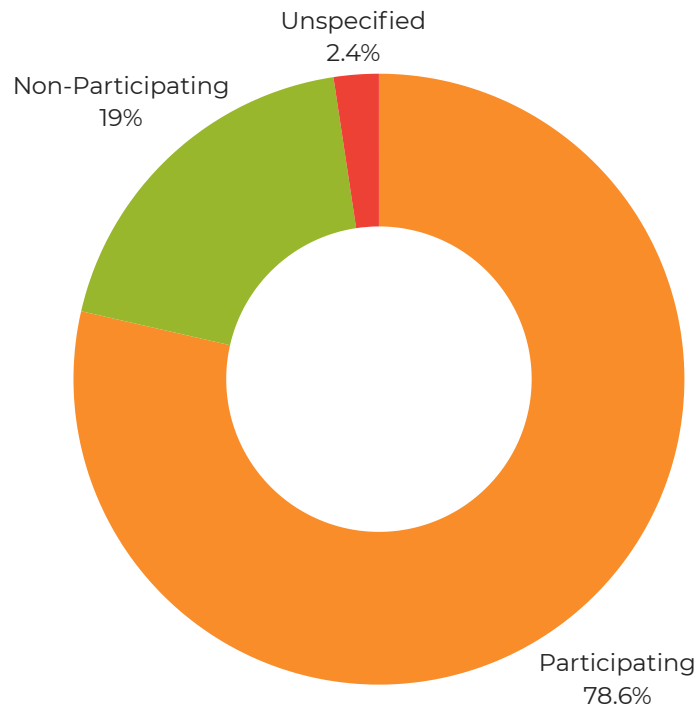


Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation

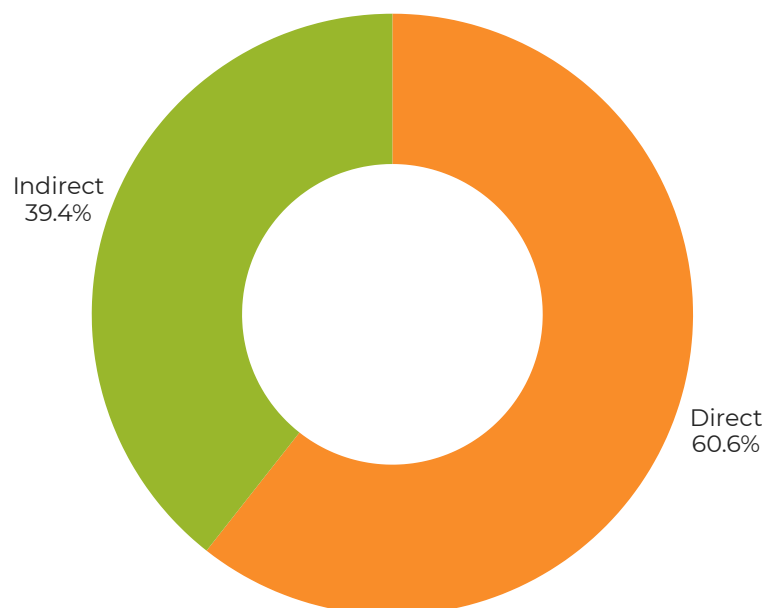


2.2.6 Visual & Design Arts

Participation Vs Non-participation

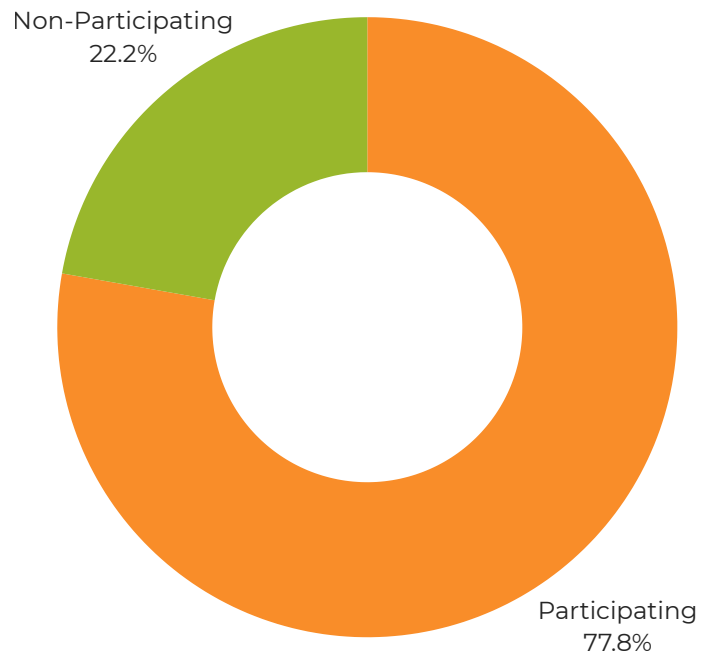


Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation

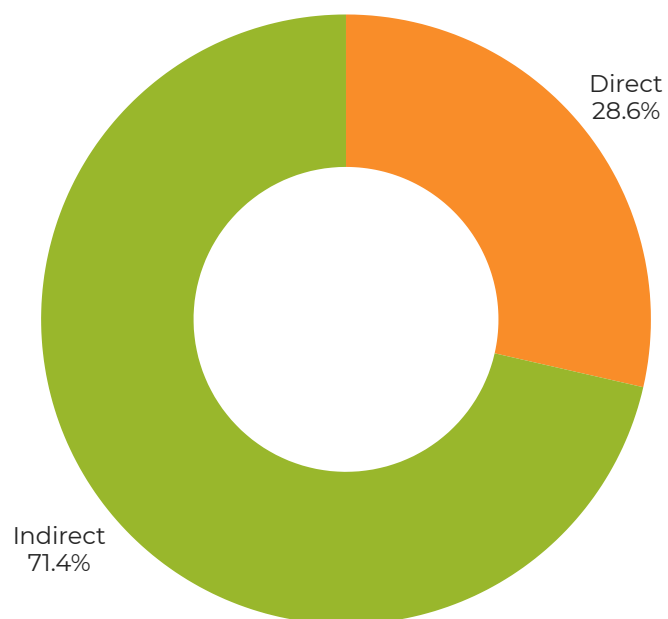


2.2.7 Crafts & Material Arts

Participation Vs Non-participation

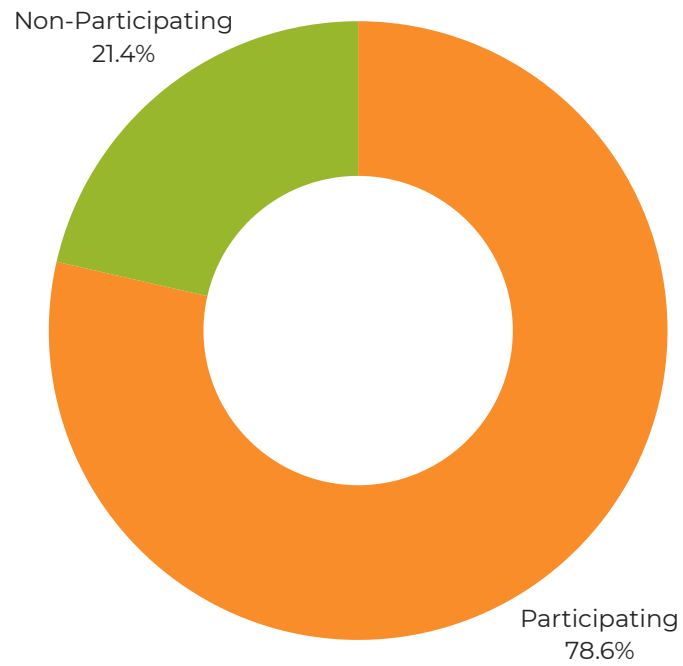


Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation

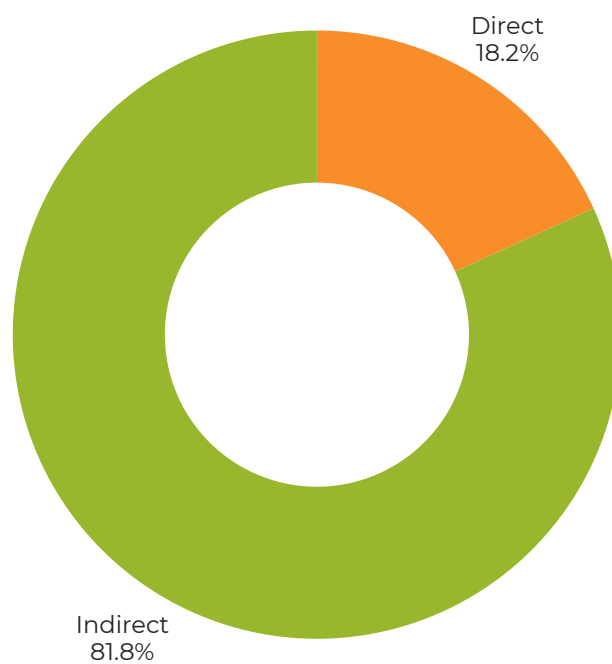


2.2.8 Cultural Heritage & Indigenous Knowledge

Participation Vs Non-participation

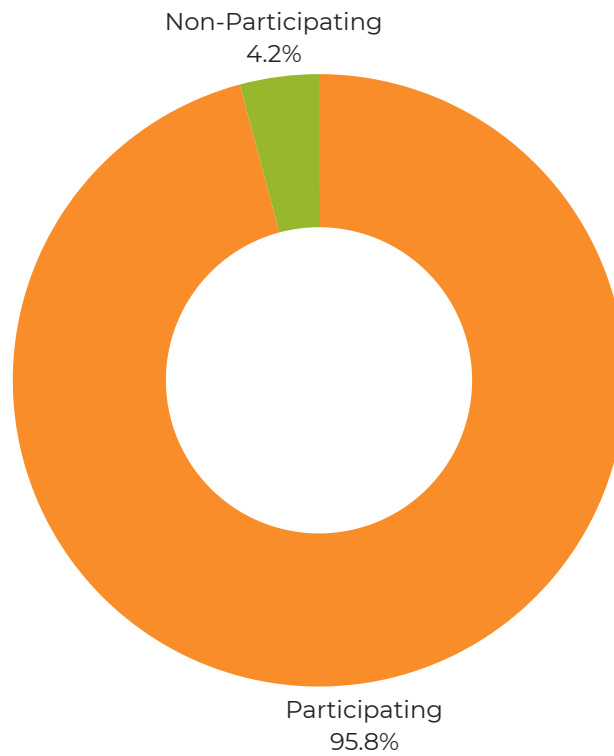


Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation



2.2.9 Education & Capacity Building

Participation Vs Non-participation

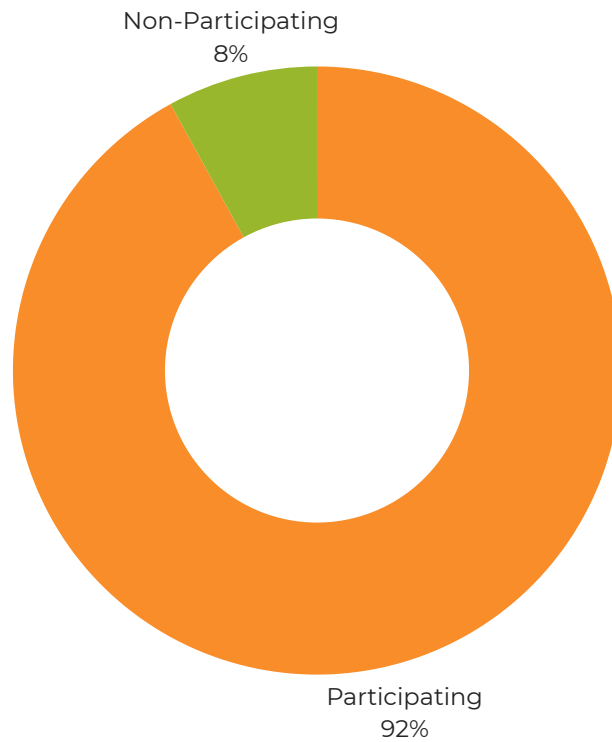


Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation



2.2.10 Creative Business & Management

Participation Vs Non-participation



Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation



2.2.11 Interactive & Emerging Media

Participation Vs Non-participation



Participating
100%

Direct Participation Vs Indirect Participation



Direct
100%

Across the creative sectors represented in this survey, civic engagement is consistently high, though the intensity, modality, and public visibility of participation vary meaningfully by discipline. A clear pattern emerges in which public-facing, narrative-driven, and fast-turnaround creative fields, such as performance and live arts, film and video, digital content creation, writing, journalism, and visual design, exhibit the highest levels of direct action. These categories combine immediacy, audience reach, and expressive tools that naturally extend into civic mobilisation, public commentary, and real-time participation in demonstrations. In many of these fields, the majority of participants engage directly, using their creative outputs as channels for critique, documentation, or advocacy.

A second cluster comprises sectors whose engagement is high but more balanced between direct and indirect participation, including education and capacity building, creative business and management, and parts of the visual arts. These practitioners often influence civic discourse through facilitative, organisational, pedagogical, or interpretive roles, complementing public expression with behind-the-scenes contributions. Their engagement tends to support infrastructure, knowledge-sharing, and coordination within civic movements, making their influence present but less immediately visible.

A third cluster, crafts, material arts, cultural heritage, and indigenous knowledge, shows consistently strong but predominantly indirect forms of participation. These modes of creative practice often involve slower production cycles, contextual or community-rooted work, or media less easily adapted to rapid commentary or public demonstrations. As a result, practitioners in these sectors tend to contribute through supportive, symbolic, or heritage-informed roles rather than visible frontline activism. Their participation underscores the culturally grounded but less public-facing ways in which civic expression manifests within traditional and craft-based disciplines.

Finally, the category of interactive and emerging media, though small in sample size, stands out as an outlier: respondents in this group reported 100% direct engagement, suggesting that creators working with new, experimental, or technologically adaptive forms of media are leveraging their tools proactively and exclusively for civic expression.

Taken together, these patterns reveal that while civic participation is a sector-wide phenomenon within Kenya's creative community, the form, tempo, and materiality of creative practice significantly shape how creatives engage, whether through direct frontline expression, supportive facilitation, cultural preservation, or technologically innovative modes of advocacy. This multi-layered engagement highlights the creative sector's diverse and evolving contributions to public discourse and civic mobilisation.

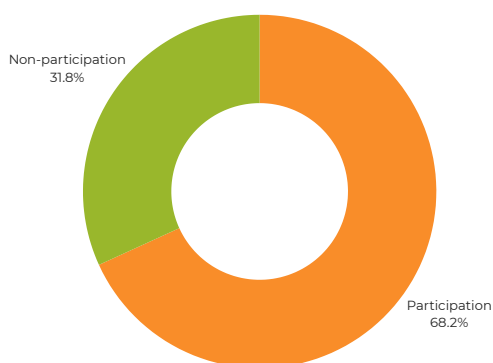
CHAPTER THREE

Participation in Demonstrations

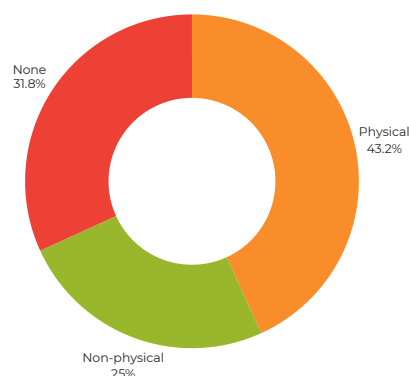
3.1 Comparing Physical and Non-physical Participation

Building on the broader analysis of civic engagement across creative fields, this section focuses specifically on participation in *maandamano* (demonstrations). It distinguishes between direct, physical involvement and non-physical forms of engagement, such as artistic expression, online activism, or supportive actions. This allows for a deeper understanding of how creatives translate their civic commitment into tangible participation, revealing both the visible and behind-the-scenes ways the sector contributes to public discourse and social action.

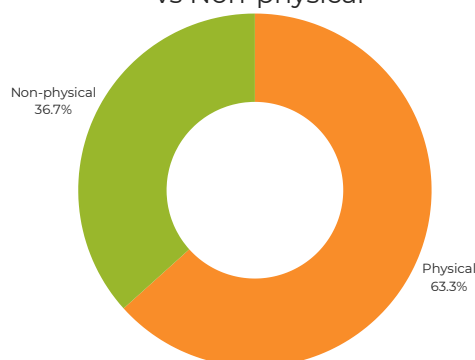
3.1.1 Demonstrations Participation Vs Non-participation



3.1.2 Physical vs Non-physical vs Non-participation

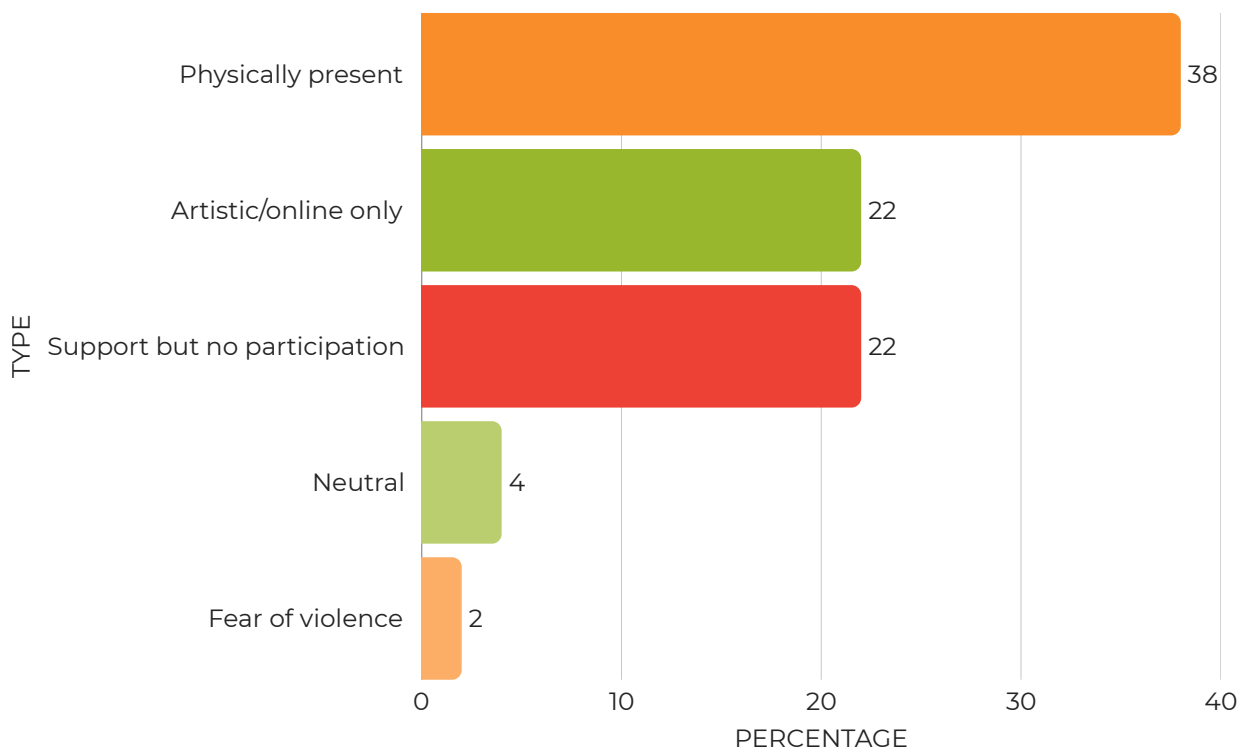


3.1.3 Physical vs Non-physical



The findings indicate that approximately 68% of creatives participated in the demonstrations, while around 32% did not. Among all respondents, 43% engaged through physical presence and 25% through non-physical avenues such as artistic or online expression. The 32% who did not participate include those who expressed support from the sidelines, those who remained neutral, and those deterred by safety concerns. Overall, while physical presence remains the most prominent form of engagement, non-physical participation represents a substantial channel through which creatives contribute, reinforcing that civic involvement in the sector extends well beyond being on the ground.

3.1.4 General Distribution



The expanded view of non-participation adds critical nuance. 22% express clear support but do not participate, while a smaller 4% remain neutral and 2% are deterred by fear of violence. This shows that non-participation is not primarily driven by indifference; rather, most of those not present in demonstrations still align with the cause but refrain from involvement for personal, professional, or contextual reasons.

3.2 Motivations & Barriers

3.2.1 Motivations

The primary motivations for participation are deeply personal and systemic. Respondents consistently cited a desire for change and the hope for a better Kenya as their main drivers.

A. Desire for Systemic Change and Better Governance

A dominant motivator is the urgent demand for a more just, accountable, and functional Kenya. Respondents consistently express frustration with corruption, bad policies, exploitative taxation, and a failing economy.

Sampled Quotes:

- “I am suffering the consequences of the broken system that we are trying to change. Simple. I want change.”
- “The greed behind the government takes away resources that ought to be used in strategising reforms and policies that ought to benefit the people.”
- “What motivates me is the dream of a better Kenya, of a better future and of better leaders.”
- “We all deserve a better system.”

B. Personal Impact and Lived Experience of Injustice

For many respondents, participation is driven by personal exposure to injustice and systemic harm. Among the issues affecting their lives directly are police brutality, over taxation, employment, and safety.

Sampled Quotes:

- “I have lost a friend.”
- “What motivates me is the hope and security of my future. What demotivates me is the fear of not living to see that future because of abductions, police brutality, and extra-judicial killings.”
- “The fact that political instability affects my work directly.”

C. Creative Responsibility & Civic Duty

Creatives see themselves not just as citizens, but as carriers of narrative, memory, and collective voice. Many feel a duty to speak, document, and challenge injustice through their craft.

Sampled Quotes:

- “Creatives are the voice and mirror of society. Many look up to them to shape public discourse.”
- “As an artist, I feel that it is my responsibility to use my voice and influence in speaking about social justice.”
- “A photo, a video, a poster — it can carry pain, truth, resistance. It can outlive the moment.”
- “I believe that I am the change that I need to see in the world, as a creative.”

D. Hope, Unity, and Collective Agency

Hope, especially among young Kenyans, emerges as a powerful motivating force. Respondents are inspired by the unity and shared purpose they witness during *maandamano*.

Sampled Quotes:

- “As a patriot, I love the unity among the young generation showing the zeal and passion for a better nation.”
- “Honestly... it’s a mix of rage and hope that keeps me going.”
- “The hope for a better Kenya.”
- “How young Kenyans express themselves.”

E. Visibility, Expression, and Opportunity for Creative Impact

A smaller but important theme: *maandamano* provide an opportunity for creatives to express themselves, document history, and showcase their work.

Sampled Quotes:

- “It gives creatives a space to showcase majority of their skills.”
- “Being able to talk about the injustices we face through our art works motivates me.”
- “Art is the greatest form of expression... it reaches people.”
- “To use my lens, my edits, my storytelling to say: we were here, we saw, we felt, we fought.”

3.2.1 Barriers

A. Violence, Insecurity, and Fear for Personal Safety

This is the strongest barrier, expressed through fear of brutality, harm, abduction, or death. Many cite chaotic or unsafe environments due to police or hooligan infiltration.

Sampled Quotes:

- “I fear violence.”
- “The fear of getting unalived demotivated me from physically engaging.”
- “Violence demotivates my participation physically.”
- “If I get hurt or killed, who will take care of my family?”

B. Economic and Professional Risk

Participation can endanger livelihoods, particularly for freelancers and young creatives who lack safety nets. Economic disruption, client loss, and instability in the creative sector are key concerns.

Sampled Quotes:

- “Clients tend to shy away from visible activists and this affects income.”
- “I am a Kenyan... during unrest, the creative sector is the most hit as we have no other way of making money.”
- “Life ni hard.” (Life is hard)
- “The constant destabilizing of the workday demotivates me.”

C. Perceived Ineffectiveness, Fatigue, and Disillusionment

Some respondents question whether *maandamano* achieve meaningful change, expressing emotional fatigue and frustration with repetitive cycles.

Sampled Quotes:

- “Saying the same thing over and over again becomes exhausting.”
- “Sometimes it feels like screaming into a void.”
- “We’re just not enough out in the streets for the government to see the need to listen.”
- “Majority of the maandamanos are not driven by a common cause.”

D. Moral or Ideological Concerns

Respondents cite concerns about hijacked protests, lack of coherence, and manipulation by political interests.

Sampled Quotes:

- “Hooligans change the narrative to take advantage of the maandamano.”
- “Political infiltration.”
- “They are not driven by a common cause... I find that a bit dishonest.”
- “I hate that maandamano bring more evil than good.”

E. Neutrality, Discomfort with Protests, or Preference for Alternative Expression

A small but relevant group simply prefers not to be in the streets or chooses alternative forms of civic expression.

Sampled Quotes:

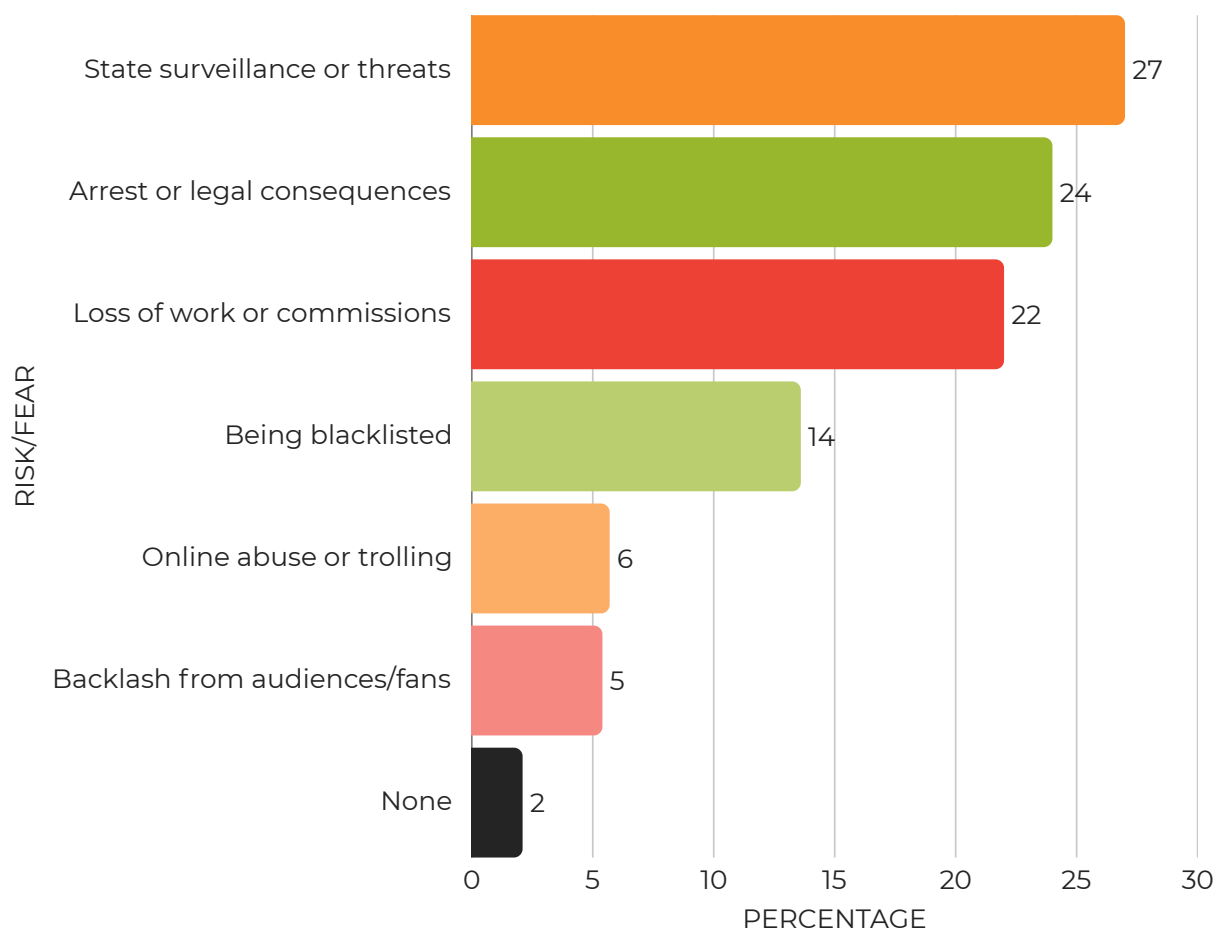
- “I just don’t like to be on the streets.”
- “We have better ways to express our feelings through our artworks.”
- “Art is enough for me to speak.”
- “Neutral.”

Across responses, creatives articulate a profound tension between the urgency to demand change and the fear and risks associated with public protest. While their motivation is rooted in lived injustice, artistic responsibility, and a desire for a better Kenya, their demotivation is driven primarily by insecurity, economic vulnerability, and disillusionment with the process. Direct effects of participation include exposure to police brutality, threats to personal safety, loss of income, social scrutiny, and the emotional toll of activism. Some creatives also reflect on moral or ideological concerns, such as balancing personal beliefs with collective action, while others choose neutrality or alternative forms of expression, avoiding protests due to strategic caution or preference for behind-the-scenes engagement. This duality defines how creatives navigate maandamano: deeply committed to change, yet profoundly aware of the cost, both tangible and ethical, of showing up.

3.3 Reported Risks and Challenges

Creative practitioners in Kenya navigate a complex landscape when expressing political views through their work. While art provides a platform for social commentary and civic engagement, it also exposes artists to various risks, ranging from legal consequences to professional and social repercussions. This section explores the types and prevalence of these perceived risks across the creative sector as submitted by the survey respondents.

3.3.1 Prevalence of Risks and Fears of Political Expression Through Art

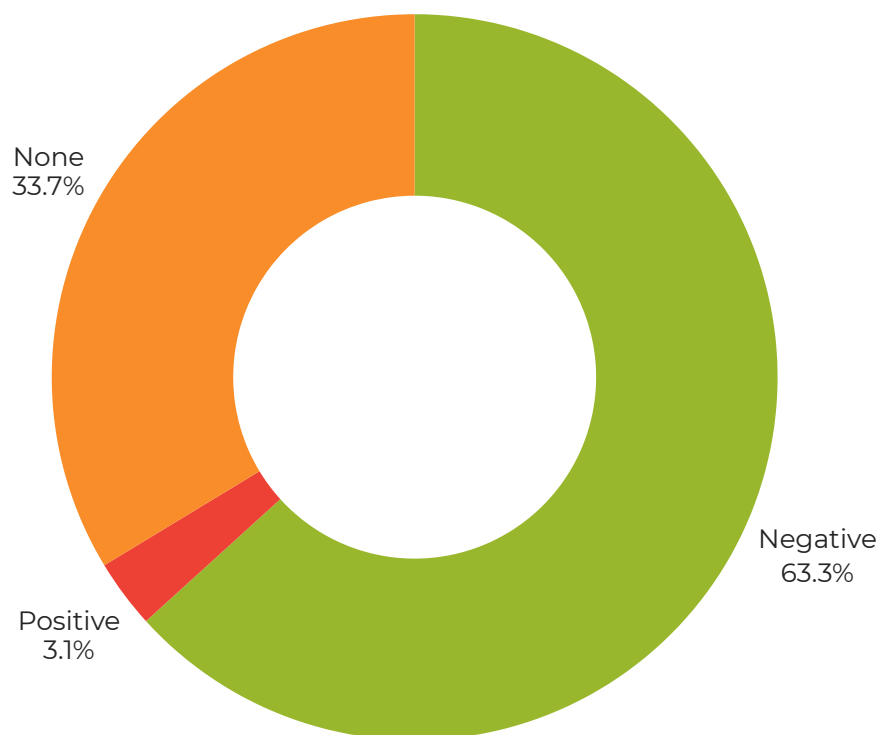


Creative practitioners in Kenya report multiple risks when expressing political views through their art. The most cited concerns are state surveillance or threats (27%), arrest or legal consequences (24%), and loss of work or commissions (22%). Fewer respondents identified risks such as being blacklisted (14%), online abuse or trolling (6%), or backlash from audiences/fans (5%), while only 2% reported no associated risks. This distribution underscores that the creative sector faces both systemic and social pressures when engaging in political expression, influencing how and where artists choose to participate.

3.4 Impact on Work and Opportunities

Participation in demonstrations can influence creatives not only in terms of civic engagement but also in their capacity to produce, perform, and earn from their work. This section examines how recent demonstrations have affected the professional and creative activities of artists, highlighting both disruptions and potential positive outcomes.

Impact on Ability to Create, Perform, or Earn

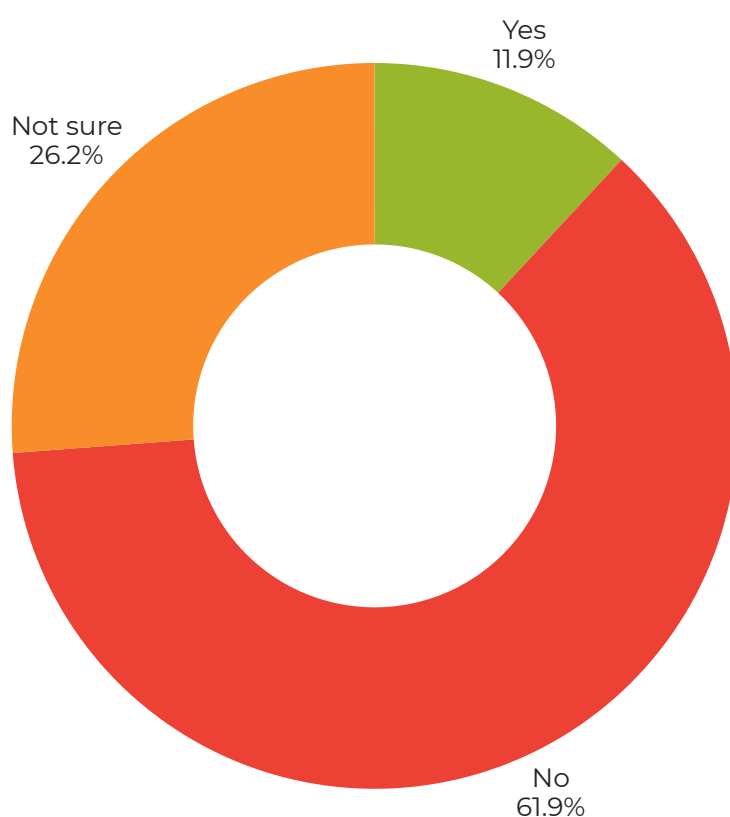


The majority of creatives (63%) reported that their ability to create, perform, or earn from their craft was negatively affected during demonstrations. A small fraction (3%) experienced a positive impact, while roughly one-third (34%) indicated no significant change. These findings suggest that while demonstrations provide a platform for civic expression, they can also disrupt artistic practice and livelihoods, reflecting both the risks and vulnerabilities that creatives face during periods of public unrest.

3.4.1 Professional Repercussions for Public Expression

While civic engagement provides a platform for creatives to voice social and political concerns, it can sometimes intersect with professional opportunities. This section examines whether participation in demonstrations or public expression during such events has affected creatives' access to jobs, showcases, or funding, shedding light on perceived and actual professional risks.

Question: Have you ever been denied an opportunity (e.g., job, showcase, funding) because of your public expression during *maandamano* or similar events?



A minority of creatives (12%) reported being denied opportunities due to their public expression during demonstrations. The majority (62%) indicated they had not faced such barriers, while about a quarter (26%) were unsure. This suggests that while professional repercussions for civic expression are not widespread, uncertainty exists, highlighting a perceived risk among creatives that may influence their willingness to publicly engage.

CHAPTER FOUR

Generational Shifts in Creative Activism

This section examines how the current generation of creatives engages with activism differently from previous ones. Responses reveal a striking combination of fearlessness, digital fluency, and collective agency, which shapes both the methods and impact of their activism. The comparison is based on the respondents' opinions.

A. Bold, Fearless, and Direct Expression

Respondents consistently emphasized that contemporary creatives are more outspoken and unafraid of confronting social and political issues. Unlike previous generations, which often operated cautiously or relied on institutional validation, today's creatives actively challenge authority, expose injustice, and express dissent publicly.

Sampled Quotes:

- "We are loud, diverse, creative, and motivated by the desire for change; nothing else."
- "This generation is bold, unashamed, and we stand our ground... we won't stop until we see systems working, healthcare, education, no corruption."
- "No fear, creatives are ready to die fighting for their rights."

B. Strategic and Immediate Use of Digital Platforms

The internet, social media, and digital tools are central to modern creative activism. Responses highlighted the speed and reach enabled by online platforms, allowing creatives to document, critique, and mobilise in real time. Activism has become instantaneous, multi-modal, and highly visible.

Sampled Quotes:

- "A tweet, a visual, a video can become a form of protest within minutes."
- "Social media has provided an accessible platform for creatives to share and engage audiences on policy and governance."
- "Through online criticism and mobilisation, creatives are reaching a critical mass and holding both the state and society accountable."

C. Collective Identity, Solidarity, and Education

The respondents, primarily young creatives aged 18–35, demonstrate a strong sense of collective purpose and unity, often expressing solidarity across movements and communities. Respondents also noted that increased access to education and information enables them to understand policy, legislation, and civic rights, strengthening the strategic impact of their activism.”

Sampled Quotes:

- “We are united.”
- “We are certainly more awake than the previous generation.”
- “We are educating ourselves and not just treating politics as a reserve for older people.”

D. Multi-Modal, Creative Engagement

Activism is now a fusion of art, humour, aesthetics, and direct action. Creatives leverage music, film, visual storytelling, spoken word, fashion, and performance to engage audiences in ways that are both culturally resonant and highly shareable.

Sampled Quotes:

- “This generation uses aesthetic as protest, humor as critique, and digital spaces as battlefields.”
- “By creating art that speaks unspoken issues... we turn pain into powerful, shareable expression.”

E. Tensions and Challenges

Despite their boldness, respondents highlighted ongoing pressures and risks:

- Digital fatigue and burnout
- Backlash, cancel culture, and public scrutiny
- Risk of physical harm or threats
- Questioning the efficacy of activism at times

Sampled Quotes:

- “In this age of online content, artistes are forced to apologize to faceless 'fans'... the line between personal conviction and artistic expression is blurred.”
- “Even with bold expression, some fear losing livelihood or facing personal danger.”

The current generation of creative activists blends courage, digital savvy, and solidarity in unprecedented ways. Their activism is immediate, visually and emotionally compelling, and unafraid to challenge both power and complacency. At the same time, it operates within new vulnerabilities; online scrutiny, physical risks, and the psychological weight of constant engagement. This duality, bold yet burdened, united yet individually exposed, defines contemporary creative activism in Kenya.

CHAPTER FIVE

Envisioned Changes and Goals for the Creative Sector

This section captures the aspirations and visions of creatives participating in *maandamano* for a transformed creative sector. Respondents were asked to select up to three changes or end goals they hope to see realised. Across responses, key themes emerge around financial support, freedom of expression, recognition, and institutional accountability. The insights reflect a collective desire for a creative ecosystem that is equitable, empowered, and respected, where artists can work without fear, influence policy, and contribute meaningfully to national development.

5.1 Envisioned Goals



Among creatives participating in *maandamano*, the strongest aspirations centre on freedom of expression, access to funding, and recognition of art as essential to national development. There is also a notable emphasis on accountability, fair working conditions, and supportive cultural policies, highlighting a collective desire for systemic change that safeguards creative rights and ensures sustainable careers. While traditional advocacy for governance reforms appears minimal, the data underscores a sector deeply invested in structural support, legitimacy, and protection, reflecting a generation that seeks both empowerment and resilience within the creative ecosystem.

5.2 Open Opinions: Additional Reflections on Creative Activism

This section captures respondents' open-ended reflections on creative activism. Participants were invited to share insights beyond structured questions, providing nuanced perspectives on the challenges, motivations, and aspirations of creatives navigating activism in contemporary Kenya.

1. Emotional weight and resilience

Being a creative in politically charged times is emotionally taxing and carries risk. Many participants described a sense of shouting into the wind yet emphasised resilience and purpose. Even small impacts, helping someone feel seen, heard, or inspired, were considered meaningful.

- *"Being a creative during times like these isn't easy... even when it feels like no one's listening, someone always is."*
- *"If all I ever do is help one person feel seen, heard, or inspired — that's enough for me."*

2. Advocacy for freedom and systemic change

Respondents stressed that creatives themselves are not the problem, but that structural barriers, censorship, and suppression impede artistic and civic expression. There is a strong call for constitutional rights, safety, and systemic support.

- *"Artistes are the conscience of a society. They should be free to express themselves without having to watch over their shoulders."*
- *"Creatives are not the problem; it's the system that suppresses its own."*

3. Community and collective action

Many respondents emphasised the importance of solidarity among creatives. Collective advocacy, speaking in one voice, and coordinating efforts were seen as ways to amplify impact and dissuade weak links during activism.

- *"Creatives ought to come together and speak in one voice to dissuade weak links during moments of advocacy."*

4. Civic engagement and responsibility

Civic education, strategic activism, and informed participation emerged as key priorities. Respondents highlighted that activism should be purposeful and structured, rather than performative or disruptive without clear objectives.

- *"Civic education is more paramount than going for Maandamano without a clear agenda."*

5. Hope and optimism

Despite challenges, respondents expressed hope and determination. Many highlighted the value of perseverance, continuous creation, and a forward-looking mindset.

- *“Let’s keep fighting, brighter days are yet to come.”*
- *“Despite everything going on ... keep creating.”*

6. Professional and Economic Considerations

Some respondents highlighted the need for sustainable opportunities and recognition for creatives. Economic stability and professional support were seen as essential enablers for continued activism.

- *“How can we leverage the creative sector to create job opportunities for young people, promote social cohesion and celebrate diversity?”*
- *“More job opportunities that pay for artists please, especially theatre artists...”*

Creatives see themselves as both storytellers and agents of change. They acknowledge the emotional and practical risks of activism but prioritise purpose, community, and social impact over fear or personal safety. There is a strong call for freedom of expression, systemic protection, professional support, and strategic civic engagement. Hope, resilience, and collective solidarity emerge as key motivators for sustaining creative activism in contemporary Kenya.

CHAPTER SIX

Systemic Implications & Stakeholder Recommendations

This analysis reveals that creatives are not passive observers but active participants and vital narrators of Kenya's civic life. Their activism, while powerful, is precarious without institutional support.

6.1 For Creatives:

- **Build Strong Networks:** Form and strengthen creative unions or associations to provide legal and social support.
- **Document and Archive:** Continue using platforms to document events, creating a public record that counters misinformation and preserves truth.
- **Prioritise Safety:** Develop personal and collective safety protocols, including digital security and psychological support mechanisms.

6.2 For Funders & NGOs:

- **Invest in Resilience:** Fund programs that offer legal aid, digital security training, and mental health support for creative activists.
- **Provide Flexible Funding:** Create grants and emergency funds that can support creatives who lose income due to their activism or political volatility.
- **Shift Narratives:** Support research and storytelling that frames creatives not just as artists but as vital civic actors, worthy of protection and investment.

6.3 For Policy Actors & Rights Organisations:

- **Advocate for Protective Legislation:** Champion policies that safeguard freedom of expression and offer legal protection against arbitrary arrests and surveillance.
- **Ensure Accountability:** Actively engage with police and government bodies to demand accountability for violence and threats against creatives and the general public.
- **Create Safe Spaces:** Work to establish physical and digital safe zones where creative expression can occur without fear of reprisal.

6.4 For the General Public:

- **Amplify Creative Voices:** Share, engage with, and financially support creative work that speaks to social issues.
- **Recognise Their Role:** Understand that artists are a reflection of society and a barometer of its health. When they speak, it is often a voice for the collective.

Conclusion: Creatives as the Conscience of a Nation

The survey data confirms that creatives are not just cultural workers; they are the conscience of a society, the keepers of its memory, and a powerful force for change. Their unique blend of skill and passion allows them to translate complex political realities into accessible and evocative art.

Protecting and empowering them will not only nurture a thriving creative economy but also strengthen the very fabric of our democracy. As one creative poignantly stated: ***“I don’t create just for today. I create so that tomorrow never forgets.”***

Appendix

Survey Data Framework and Summaries

Overview

This appendix contains detailed summaries, tables, and coding frameworks for the survey conducted on creative activism and the experiences of creatives during public demonstrations (*maandamano*). It presents both quantitative and qualitative responses, capturing the full spectrum of participant perspectives. Open-ended responses are summarised to highlight recurring themes while the entire survey maintains respondent anonymity.

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2. Ethical Considerations
3. Data Handling and Processing
4. Analytical Tools and Processes
5. Definitions of Key Terms
6. Survey Questions Overview
7. Quantitative Data Summaries
8. Qualitative Analysis of Open-Ended Responses

1. Sampling and Distribution

1.1 Sampling Approach

- **Distribution:** Fully organic through social and peer-to-peer creative networks.
- **Dominant channels:** WhatsApp groups, social media shares, and Nairobi arts sector networks
- **Approximate survey reach:** 700 - 1,000 individuals.

1.2 Eligibility

- No formal eligibility criteria imposed.
- All individuals identifying as creatives were free to participate

1.3 Observed Sample Characteristics

- High representation from multi-disciplinary creatives (typical for urban creative hubs).
- Predominantly Nairobi-based respondents (typical due to dominant presence of creative activities and opportunities in Nairobi).

2. Ethical Considerations

2.1 Informed Consent

- A clear consent statement was included at the beginning of the survey.
- Respondents were informed that participation was anonymous.

2.2 Voluntary Participation

- The survey informed respondents that participation was voluntary.
- Most questions were optional; only a few core demographic questions were mandatory.

3. Data Handling and Processing

3.1 Data Cleaning

- Minimal cleaning required due to structured options.
- Some spelling mistakes were corrected without altering the responses.
- No removal of responses; all 102 responses were retained.
- Multi-select fields were disaggregated and counted as individual selections for analysis.

3.2 Thematic Coding of Open-Ended Responses

- Open-ended responses were coded into thematic categories.
- The specific appendix section includes:
 - Analytical Approach
 - Coding framework
 - Coding framework Frequency
 - Sample quotes

4. Analytical Tools and Processes

- Spreadsheet for primary data sorting, filtering, and charting.
- AI-assisted tabulation, categorisation, and preliminary framing of insight narratives.
- Manual interpretation and contextualisation led by Utetezi Arts and Insights.
- Analytical Consultant supervision and approvals.

5. Survey Questions Overview

5.1 Questions

The survey captured responses to the following questions:

1. What best describes your creative field? You can select more than one.
2. Where are you primarily based?
3. Age Group
4. Have you ever used your art to speak out on political or social issues?
5. Have you participated in maandamano (demonstrations) in any way? You can select more than one.
6. What motivates (or demotivates) your participation as a creative during maandamano periods?
7. (If applicable) Which change or goal do you envision for the creative sector, as a maandamano participant? (Select up to 3 that resonate with your vision)
8. What risks or fears do you associate with expressing political views through your art? (Select all that apply)
9. Have you ever been denied an opportunity (e.g., job, showcase, funding) because of your public expression during maandamano or similar events?
10. Has your ability to create, perform, or earn from your craft been affected during recent demonstrations?
11. In your view, how is this generation of creatives engaging with activism differently compared to previous ones?
12. Anything else you'd like to share on this topic? (Optional)

5.2 Types and Purpose

Question	Question Type	Description / Purpose
1	Multiple Choice / Checkboxes	To identify the different creative disciplines represented among respondents
2	Multiple Choice	To determine the geographical distribution of respondents
3	Multiple Choice	To capture the demographic age profile of respondents
4	Multiple Choice	To assess the extent of activism through creative expression
5	Multiple Choice / Checkboxes	To understand the forms and frequency of respondents' participation in protests
6	Open-ended / Short text	To explore the driving factors or barriers influencing creative engagement in activism
7	Open-ended / Short text	To capture respondents' aspirations or desired outcomes for the sector
8	Multiple Choice / Checkboxes	To identify perceived personal or professional risks in politically expressive art
9	Multiple Choice	To examine experiences of exclusion or discrimination linked to activism
10	Multiple Choice	To evaluate the impact of demonstrations on creative work and livelihood

11	Open-ended	To explore perceptions of generational shifts in creative activism
12	Open-ended	To provide space for additional insights or experiences beyond structured questions

6. Quantitative Data Summaries

6.1 Question 4: Have you ever used your art to speak out on political or social issues?

Response Category	Count	%
Yes	47	46.5%
Not directly, but my work often touches on these themes	40	39.6%
No	13	12.9
Largely on social issues (long-form response)	1	1%

Total respondents: **101**

6.2 Question 5: Have you participated in maandamano (demonstrations) in any way? You can select more than one.

Response Category	Count	%
Yes – physically present	50	49.0%
Yes – through artistic and/or online expression	53	52.0%
No – but I support the cause(s)	24	23.5%
No – I chose to stay neutral	6	5.9%
No – I support the cause but fear violence (physical or virtual)	2	2%

Total respondents: **102**

Total selections: **135** (multiple selection allowed)

6.3 Question 8: Risks or fears associated with expressing political views through art (Select all that apply)

Response Category	Number of Respondents	%
State surveillance or threats	71	69.61%
Arrest or legal consequences	65	63.73%
Loss of work or commissions	55	53.92%
Being blacklisted	37	36.27%
Backlash from audiences/fans	22	21.57%
Online abuse or trolling	18	17.65%
None	7	6.86%

Total respondents: **102**

Total selections: **275** (multiple selection allowed)

6.4 Question 9: Have you ever been denied an opportunity (e.g., job, showcase, funding) because of your public expression during maandamano or similar events?

Response Category	Number of Respondents	%
Yes	10	9.80%
No	66	64.71%
Not sure	27	25.49%

Total respondents: **102**

Total selections: **102**

6.5 Question 10: Has your ability to create, perform, or earn from your craft been affected during recent demonstrations?

Response Category	Number of Respondents	%
Yes – negatively	62	60.78%
No significant change	36	35.29%
Yes – positively	3	2.94%

Total respondents: **102**

Total selections: **101**

7. Qualitative Analysis of Open-Ended Responses

7.1 Analytical Approach:

Responses to the question “What motivates (or demotivates) your participation as a creative during maandamano periods?” were analysed using inductive thematic analysis.

The process followed four steps:

1. **Familiarisation:** All responses were read multiple times to understand surface meaning and underlying sentiment.
2. **Open Coding:** Segments of text were labeled with initial codes capturing motivations or demotivating factors.
3. **Code Grouping & Theme Development:** Similar codes were clustered into broader categories. These were refined into major themes and sub-themes, representing both motivators and barriers.
4. **Theme Validation:** Themes were checked against the raw data to ensure coherence, clear boundaries, and adequate representation.

This allowed the analysis to move from individual expressions to collective patterns across the creative community.

7.2 Question 6: What motivates (or demotivates) your participation as a creative during maandamano periods?

7.2.1 Coding Framework

7.2.1.1 Motivations

Code	Description	Example Extract
M1. Desire for systemic change	Calls for better governance, end to corruption, reform, justice.	“I want change.”
M2. Personal experience of injustice	Motivated by harm or injustice affecting self or others.	“I have lost a friend.”
M3. Creative responsibility / civic duty	Feeling obligated as a creative to document, speak out, or influence society.	“Creatives are the voice and mirror of society.”

M4. Hope and unity	Inspiration from youth solidarity, optimism about a better future.	"The unity among young people motivates me."
M5. Creative expression and visibility	Using art to express dissent, document history, or showcase skills.	"Art is the greatest form of expression."

7.2.1.2 Barriers

Code	Description	Example Extract
D1. Violence and insecurity	Fear of police brutality, abductions, hooligan infiltration, death.	"I fear violence."
D2. Economic and professional risk	Loss of income, client fear, instability in the creative sector.	"Clients tend to shy away from visible activists."
D3. Fatigue and perceived ineffectiveness	Emotional exhaustion, doubt about protest outcomes, repetition.	"Screaming into a void."
D4. Political infiltration / moral concerns	Distrust due to hijacking, lack of clarity, or dishonesty.	"Majority of maandamanos lack a common cause."
D5. Preference for alternative expression / aversion to protests	Discomfort with physical protests, preference for digital/artistic activism.	"I just don't like to be on the streets."

7.2.2 Coding Frequency Summary

(Note: One response may contain multiple codes.)

7.2.2.1 Motivations (Topline Frequencies)

Theme	Count	Weight in Responses
M1. Desire for systemic change	59	Very common
M2. Personal injustice	21	Moderately common
M3. Creative responsibility & civic duty	33	Highly common
M4. Hope, unity, collective agency	24	Moderately common
M5. Creative expression & visibility	17	Less common but meaningful

7.2.2.2 Barriers (Topline Frequencies)

Theme	Count	Weight in Responses
D1. Violence & insecurity	52	Dominant barrier
D2. Economic/professional risk	18	Moderately common
D3. Fatigue & ineffectiveness	16	Emerging concern
D4. Political infiltration & moral concerns	13	Moderate
D5. Preference for alternative expression	9	Small but relevant

7.3 Question 11: In your view, how is this generation of creatives engaging with activism differently compared to previous ones?

7.3.1 Coding Framework

Primary Theme	Sub-Themes / Codes	Definition / Notes	Illustrative Quotes
Boldness & Fearlessness	Outspoken, Direct, Courageous	Willingness to publicly address political and social issues without fear	"They are bold, unashamed, and stand their ground... we won't stop until we see systems working."
Digital Engagement	Social media activism, Digital reach, Immediacy	Leveraging online platforms for rapid communication, mobilization, and awareness	"We're not waiting for institutions... a tweet, a visual, a video can become a form of protest within minutes."
Knowledge & Civic Awareness	Educated, Informed, Rights-conscious	Understanding political processes, laws, and social issues; ability to leverage knowledge in activism	"This generation is educated and they understand their rights... actively keeping tabs on senate and parliament proceedings."
Multi-Modal Expression	Art as activism, Creative channels, Aesthetic protest	Using diverse artistic forms, video, music, poetry, fashion, to convey political messages	"This generation uses aesthetic as protest, humor as critique, and digital spaces as battlefields."
Purpose & Impact	Commitment to change, Urgency, Solidarity	Motivation rooted in creating tangible change, collective action, and social impact	"We are loud, diverse, creative, and motivated by the desire for change; nothing else."
Tensions & Risks	Burnout, Vulnerability, Cancel culture	Challenges faced due to outspoken activism, including personal risk, social backlash, or emotional fatigue	"In this age of online content, artistes are forced to apologize... the line between personal conviction and artistic expression is blurred."

7.3.2 Coding Frequency Summary

Primary Theme	Number of Responses (Approx.)	Proportion of Total (%)
Boldness & Fearlessness	65	64%
Digital Engagement	50	49%
Knowledge & Civic Awareness	22	22%
Multi-Modal Expression	38	37%
Purpose & Impact	40	39%
Tensions & Risks	18	18%

Note: Many responses were coded under multiple themes. Percentages indicate the proportion of total responses where the theme appeared.

7.4 Question 12: Anything else you'd like to share on this topic? (Optional)

7.4.1 Coding Framework

Primary Theme	Sub-Themes / Codes	Definition / Notes	Illustrative Quotes
Emotional Weight & Resilience	Emotional toll, persistence, purpose	Highlights the psychological and emotional strain of activism, and strategies to maintain resilience	"Being a creative during times like these isn't easy... even when it feels like no one's listening, someone always is."
Advocacy for Freedom & Systemic Change	Freedom of expression, Safety, Constitutional rights	Focus on structural barriers and the need for systemic support and protection for creatives	"Artistes are the conscience of a society. They should be free to express themselves without having to watch over their shoulders."
Community & Collective Action	Unity, Collaboration, Amplification	Calls for solidarity among creatives to increase impact and mitigate weak links in advocacy	"Creatives ought to come together and speak in one voice to dissuade weak links during moments of advocacy."
Civic Engagement & Responsibility	Civic education, Strategic activism, Impactful participation	Emphasis on informed activism, thoughtful participation, and maximizing social impact	"Civic education is more paramount than going for Maandamano without a clear agenda."
Hope & Optimism	Perseverance, Motivation, Vision for change	Maintaining a forward-looking perspective despite challenges, emphasizing ongoing creation and impact	"Despite everything going on ... keep creating." "Let's keep fighting, brighter days are yet to come."
Professional & Economic Considerations	Opportunities, Jobs for creatives, Sector development	Highlighting practical needs for career sustainability and sectoral growth	"How can we leverage the creative sector to create job opportunities for young people, promote social cohesion and celebrate diversity."

7.4.2 Coding Frequency Summary

Primary Theme	Number of Responses (Approx.)	Proportion of Total (%)
Emotional Weight & Resilience	12	40%
Advocacy for Freedom & Systemic Change	10	33%
Community & Collective Action	6	20%
Civic Engagement & Responsibility	4	13%
Hope & Optimism	8	27%
Professional & Economic Considerations	3	10%

Note: Many responses were coded under multiple themes. Percentages indicate the proportion of total responses where the theme appeared.

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Full Citation (for reports, articles, or academic references):

Utetezi Arts and Insights (2026). Creatives and Public Demonstrations: Participation, Risks, and Impact. Available at: utetezi.org.

Short/In-Text Citation (for academic papers or media references):

Utetezi Arts and Insights, 202

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